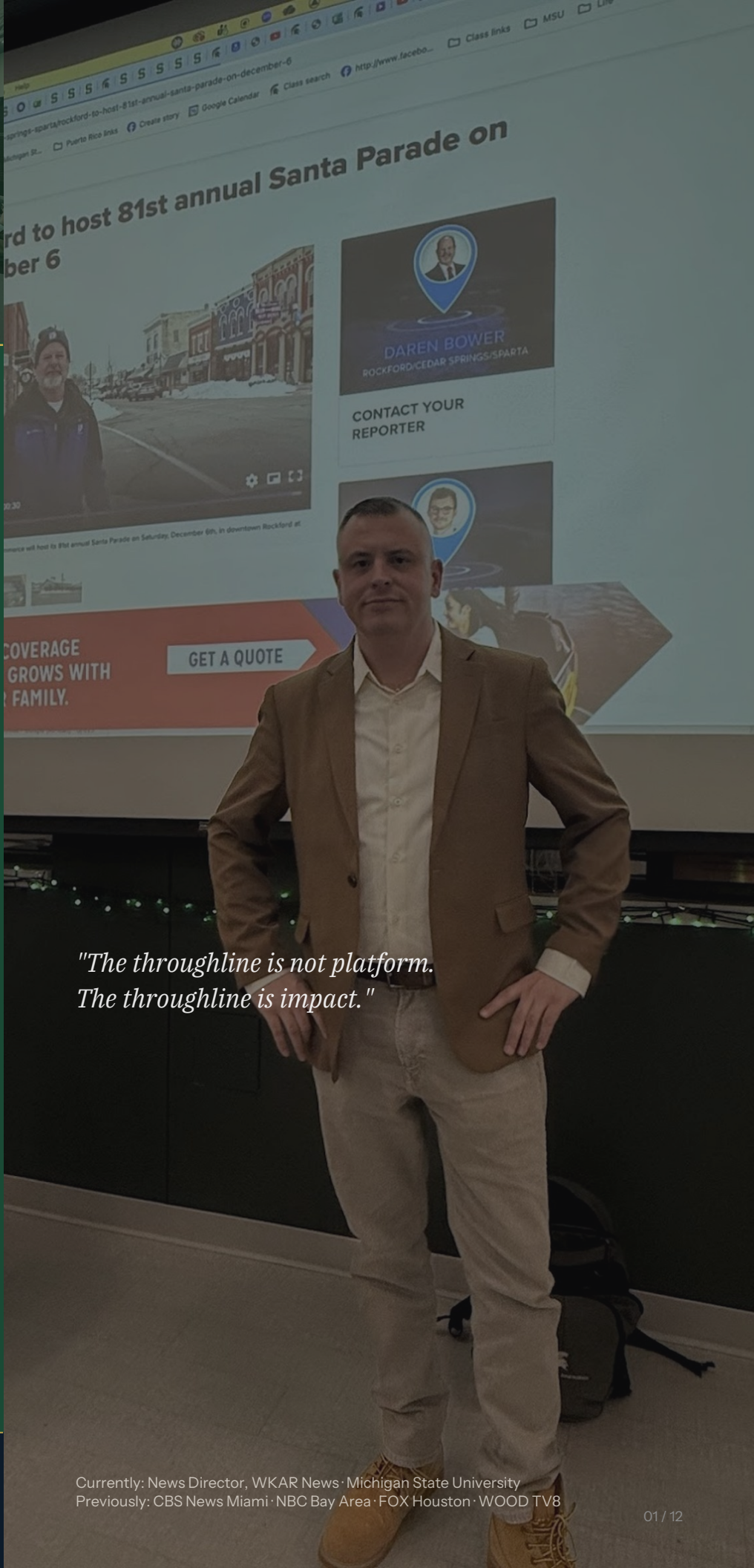




ANDREW GILLFILLAN

Newsroom Leader
Digital Transformation Builder
Impact Storytelling Strategist

*News Director · WKAR News
Michigan State University*

Twenty-five years. Eight markets. One impact filter.

*"The throughline is not platform.
The throughline is impact."*

FROM NEWSROOM LEADERSHIP TO CIVIC INTELLIGENCE.



The 25-Year Arc

Andrew Gillfillan has spent 25 years leading journalism through major transformation — from traditional local television in Grand Rapids to top-10 markets in San Francisco, Houston and Miami, and now leading a public media newsroom at Michigan State University.

His current work at WKAR is focused on transforming a traditional public media operation into a more digital, audience-aware, civic-impact newsroom — connecting impact storytelling with measurable audience growth.



WKAR News · Michigan State University

The Throughline

- **Impact Storytelling**
Every story passes an impact filter.
- **Digital Audience Growth**
Flat baseline to breakout weeks.
- **Product Development**
Built The Signal from scratch.
- **Politics & Civic**
Politics 2026 — owning Mid-Michigan.
- **Student Mentorship**
Developing the next generation.
- **AI-Assisted Workflows**



WOOD TV8 Grand Rapids · Career Foundation

*"Local journalism wins when every story passes an impact filter:
Does this hold power accountable? Does this make someone's life clearer?
Does this connect readers to something that matters?"*

THE SIGNAL

A Sunday civic briefing built for the week ahead.

Retired a lower-performing lifestyle newsletter and rebuilt as a forward-looking civic product aligned with WKAR News.

• Data center expansion accelerates as utilities prepare for more

"From lifestyle to civic. From passive newsletter to public service."

31% Subscriber Growth	1,690 Subscribers in <4 Months	56.8% Avg Open Rate	65.3% Peak Open Rate
8.3% Avg Click Rate	31,600+ Total Sends	16,600+ Total Opens	2,400+ Total Clicks

WHAT THE SIGNAL DELIVERS

- **New This Morning**
Top civic stories to start Sunday
- **What Roth's Watching**
Capitol context from WKAR
- **In-Depth**
Enterprise and long-form coverage
- **Week Ahead**
Meetings, key dates, civic planning
- **Data Center Tracker**
Statewide infrastructure reporting
- **The Signal Voice**
News Director editorial perspective



WKAR News reporter Andrew Roth covers local government and civic affairs across Mid-Michigan. You can hear his reporting on 90.5 FM and track his breaking stories.

Michigan House Speaker Matt Hall is floating a \$4 billion tax overhaul that would eliminate the State Education Tax, personal property taxes, the real estate transfer tax and the pop-up tax. He said he would also require utilities to cut \$1 billion in energy rates if they benefit. Hall has not provided details on how the cuts would be covered, but he says schools and local governments would not lose funding. Democrats are already sounding off, including [this week's Off The Record](#). Expect this to loom large over the Governor's State of the State and upcoming budget negotiations.

2. Whitmer's final State of the State

Governor Gretchen Whitmer delivers her eighth and final State of the State address Wednesday. Her office says she will focus on affordability, education and health care. With Republicans pitching major tax changes, watch for how she frames the affordability debate and whether she



WHAT WE'RE TRACKING NOW

- DTE says it has roughly 3 gigawatts in late-stage negotiations for **additional large data centers** in Michigan. That's on top of 1.4 gigawatts already under contract.
- No new locations have been publicly identified yet. But across the state, communities are



WKAR Morning Edition host [Melorie Benay](#) tracks the public meetings that matter across Mid-Michigan. Here's where decisions are being made this week — and how you can show up.

MONDAY | 6:00 p.m.
[St. Johns](#)
[Williamston](#)
[Webberville](#)

MONDAY | 7:00 p.m.
[Charlotte](#)

LAST INTAKE · 2026-05-31

30 DIGITAL AUDIENCE GROWTH

records each seen

AI cleaned 100.0%

38 of 38 eligible

Parcel matched

26 of 26 eligible · 4 N/A

Geo coded

26 of 26 eligible · 4 N/A

Sunbiz matched (owner or contractor)

0 of 27 eligible · 3 N/A · 27 missing

Accela detail

0 of 26 eligible · 4 N/A · 26 missing

PERMIT TYPES

LAST 7 DAYS

1,089

permits filed

AI cleaned 100.0%

38 of 38 eligible

Parcel matched

26 of 26 eligible · 4 N/A

Geo coded

26 of 26 eligible · 4 N/A

Sunbiz matched (owner or contractor)

694 of 936 eligible · 153 N/A · 242 missing

Accela detail

698 of 738 eligible · 351 N/A · 40 missing

PERMIT TYPES

LAST 14 DAYS

2,376

permits filed

AI cleaned 100.0%

38 of 38 eligible

Parcel matched

26 of 26 eligible · 4 N/A

Geo coded

26 of 26 eligible · 4 N/A

Sunbiz matched (owner or contractor)

1,555 of 2,084 eligible · 292 N/A · 529 missing

Accela detail

1,518 of 1,558 eligible · 818 N/A · 40 missing

PERMIT TYPES

LAST 21 DAYS

3,799

permits filed

AI cleaned 100.0%

3,799 of 3,799 eligible

Parcel matched

2,395 of 2,534 eligible · 1,265 N/A · 139 missing

Geo coded

2,534 of 2,534 eligible · 1,265 N/A · 1,091 missing

Sunbiz matched (owner or contractor)

2,351 of 3,442 eligible · 357 N/A · 1,091 missing

Accela detail

2,507 of 2,547 eligible · 1,252 N/A · 40 missing

PERMIT TYPES

ALL-TIME

117,152

permits filed

AI cleaned 100.0%

117,152 of 117,152 eligible

Parcel matched

22,554 of 78,305 eligible · 38,847 N/A · 55,751 missing

Geo coded

41,697 of 78,305 eligible · 38,847 N/A · 36,608 missing

Sunbiz matched (owner or contractor)

56,591 of 73,550 eligible · 43,602 N/A · 16,959 missing

Accela detail

15,312 of 79,459 eligible · 37,693 N/A · 64,147 missing

PERMIT TYPES

FLAT BASELINE TO BREAKOUT WEEKS.

WKAR.org began outperforming typical station benchmarks after a digital-first newsroom push.

5x–7x

Peak-Week Pageview
Growth vs. Baseline

100K+

Weekly Pageviews
at Peak

7x–10x

Peak Active-User
Growth vs. Baseline

BEFORE & AFTER

SPRING 2025 BASELINE

- ~10,000–20,000 weekly pageviews
- ~6,000–12,000 weekly active users
- Engaged hours: flat, ~90–160/week
- Standard public media benchmarks

AFTER JUNE 2025

- + Breakout weeks: 50,000+ pageviews
- + Peak weeks above 100,000 pageviews
- + Active-user spikes: 30K, 50K, 80K
- + Engaged-time growth: est. 6x–10x

THREE EDITORIAL MOVES

01 Digital Story Selection

Reframed the newsroom around what readers actually need, not what is traditionally broadcast-first.

02 Search Visibility

SEO discipline, stronger headlines, structured story packaging and topic clusters around enterprise coverage.

03 Social Conversation

Put WKAR reporting inside the places where people were already talking — Nextdoor, Facebook Groups, Reddit.



Estimates based on trend chart analysis. Language: led a strategy that corresponded with repeated breakout moments and stronger benchmarks.

ANDREW GILLFILLAN

POLITICS 2026

Building WKAR's next civic product.

A yearlong election strategy built around hyperlocal politics, real-time voter information, public media trust and a visible politics team.

On The Record, Rep. Tyrone Carter, D-Detroit, weighs in on the property tax cuts proposed by Gov. Gretchen Whitmer and House Speaker Matt Hall. He also responds to gubernatorial candidate Mike Duggan's criticism of the Democratic trifecta — and shares his view on how the former Detroit mayor may fare in November.

"We are in the capital city. We own politics in Mid-Michigan."

\$3B SHOWDOWN

Four Pillars of the Plan

01 Hyperlocal Politics Reporter

Dedicated reporter covering city councils, county boards, townships, school boards and community-level policy across Mid-Michigan.

02 Real-Time Civic Hub

A dedicated Politics 2026 landing page — voter resources, candidate coverage, issue explainers, election dates, results and accountability reporting.

03 Visible WKAR Politics Team

A branded team connecting two Capitol correspondents with local reporting. Public-facing identity. Institutional authority.

04 Multi-Platform Public Service

Radio, web, TV, streaming, newsletters and social. Voter-focused civic infrastructure — not horse-race coverage.

CIVIC INTELLIGENCE, NOT COMMODITY NEWS.

A newsroom strategy built around depth, context and issues that affect daily life.

Public media should not simply duplicate daily headlines.

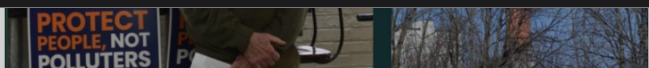
Its value is context, explanation, accountability and trust.

The goal is not just to publish stories.

The goal is to help people understand systems.

COVERAGE BUILT AROUND COMMUNITY LIFE

- Local Government
- Schools & Education
- Housing Development
- Data Centers
- Climate & Environment
- Groundwater Health
- Public Safety
- Transportation
- Property Taxes
- Political Accountability
- Community Change
- Mall & Retail Shift
- School Leadership
- Water Policy
- Public Money



IN-DEPTH #2

"We deserve clean water":

ANDREW GILLFILLAN

OR

SIGNAL EDITIONS

- Superintendent Pipeline
- Groundwater Near Erickson Plant
- Data Center Tracker
- Community Meetings Coverage
- Off the Record Politics
- St. Johns Local Feature
- Property Tax Debate
- Coal Ash / Environmental Health

Welcome to the four
Signal.

When I moved back
summer to lead WK
stood out. Sundays
should. Mid-Michiga
stronger, forward-lo
the week.

That's why we built

In the last 30 days, **readers** have joined
we're listening. This
the **Nextdoor app** s
shows up directly in

This newsletter is a
goal is simple: deliv
the week ahead and
our region.

AI AS NEWSROOM INFRASTRUCTURE.

Self-taught. Nights and weekends. Building practical systems to expand newsroom capacity.

Self-Taught. Nights and Weekends.

Andrew is independently building AI-powered systems using ChatGPT, Grok, Gemini, Claude and related tools. This is self-directed experimentation outside normal newsroom structure — focused on workflow intelligence, not gimmicks.

The goal: finding leads earlier, tracking public records, monitoring civic signals, cleaning data, building dashboards, and generating structured editorial briefs.

SYSTEMS BEING BUILT

- **Community Meeting Radar**
Monitor agendas, minutes, public notices across Mid-Michigan.
- **Civic Signals Tracker**
Track local government, spot patterns, generate reporting leads.
- **Data Pipelines & Dashboards**
Permit tracking, automated enrichment, editorial briefs.
- **Lead Generation System**
Public records, zoning, inspection data — earlier stories.

Three Principles

AI accelerates reporting, not replaces judgment.

Human editors retain full editorial authority. AI surfaces information faster.

AI expands capacity without compromising standards.

Small teams can track at the scale of much larger operations.

Small newsrooms need to listen at scale.

Community meetings, zoning boards, permit filings — the civic layer most newsrooms miss.

TOOLS IN USE

ChatGPT

Grok

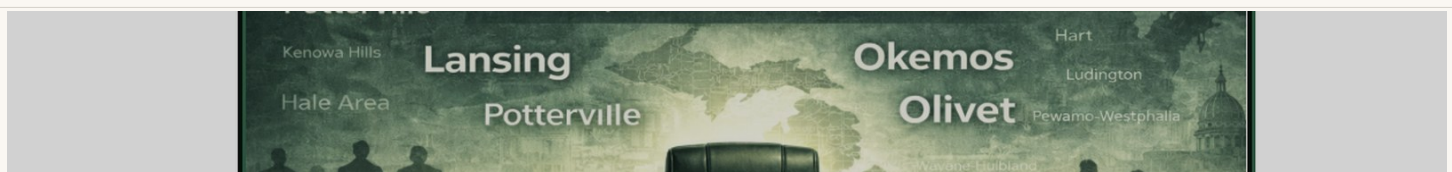
Gemini

Claude

Python

Supabase

Custom Dashboards



ENTERPRISE COVERAGE I LED.

Multi-part investigations. Dedicated digital hubs. Reporter coordination. Depth and discipline.

FEATURED PROJECT

Michigan's Data Center Divide

Multi-part investigation · Statewide · Ongoing hub

Statewide investigation into Michigan's data center boom — energy demand, water use, community impact, zoning, transparency and public policy. Andrew initiated the hub, coordinated reporters and built the editorial framework, turning a complex development issue into landmark public-service journalism.

- Multiple reporters coordinated
- Dedicated digital hub with ongoing tracker
- Energy + water + zoning + policy lens
- Positioned WKAR as the leading source

ADDITIONAL ENTERPRISE COVERAGE

Superintendent Pipeline · Coal Ash / Groundwater · Property Tax Accountability

Data Center Moratoriums · Local Government Watchdog · School Leadership Pipelines

EDITORIAL APPROACH

Initiate

Story concept and civic need identified before assigning.

Commission

Multiple reporters, each owning a specific angle.

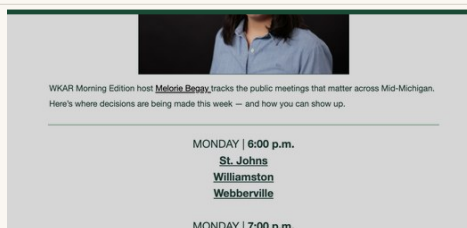
Structure

Hub built — landing page, digital architecture, SEO.

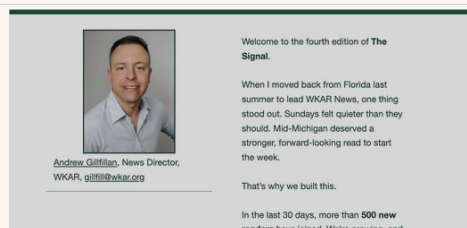
Sustain

Follow-up coverage, reader engagement, ongoing updates.

"Enterprise journalism is a structural commitment to depth, patience and civic accountability. It separates a newsroom from a news feed."



The Signal · In-Depth



The Signal · Analytics



WKAR · Anchor Desk

BUILDING THE NEXT NEWSROOM.

Teaching producers, reporters and students how to make journalism memorable, useful and clear.

Michigan State University

Andrew guest lectures and mentors students at Michigan State University — newscast production, story development, writing, editorial judgment and audience impact. He brings 25 years of real newsroom experience into student training.

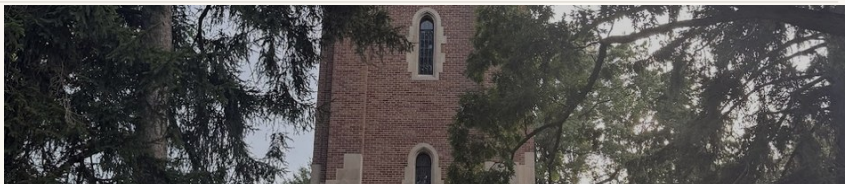
Signature Session: "Making a Memorable Newscast"

Journalism as craft and public service — how to make stories memorable, not just complete.

CBS News Miami — Talent Builder

Hired and onboarded 50+ journalists in one year. Built coaching frameworks. Developed reporters and producers into stronger editorial leaders.

"The best editorial leadership is often invisible because it shows up in the quality of the work."



AT MICHIGAN STATE

- "Making a Memorable Newscast"
- Newscast production coaching
- Editorial judgment training
- Story development workshops
- 25 years of real-room experience

TESTED IN CRISIS.

*Wildfires, hurricanes, floods,
heatwaves, shootings, storms.*

*"Weather is where journalism meets
people's lives. Severe weather requires
urgency, accuracy and calm leadership."*

CALIFORNIA WILDFIRES

- Tubbs Fire — evacuations, live tracking
- Camp Fire — deadliest CA wildfire
- Orange skies over Bay Area
- Red Flag Fire Warning coverage
- Bay Area Heatwave, multi-day
- Bob Redell — live fire zone shot

HURRICANE COVERAGE

- Hurricane Ian — CBS News Miami
- Ian's Wrath — Fort Myers aftermath
- Hurricane Nicole — landfall
- Tropical systems — invest tracking
- Key West storm surge prep
- Houston flooding — FOX market

BREAKING NEWS

- VTA mass shooting — Silicon Valley
- CHP officer injured — live breaking
- Bay Area earthquakes
- President Ford memorial — WOOD TV8
- Colts Super Bowl — WISH-TV
- Butler NCAA Championship run



25 YEARS. EIGHT MARKETS.

One impact filter.

WOOD TV8

GRAND RAPIDS, MI

Intern → Senior Mgmt · 8 Years

Career foundation. President Gerald R. Ford memorial coverage. Rose from intern to senior roles. Eight years of growth across all departments.

WDIV

DETROIT, MI

Morning EP · Top-10 Market

Led morning newscasts in one of the nation's largest markets. Fast-paced, high-stakes daily production leadership.

FOX Television Stations

HOUSTON, TX

Executive Producer · Top-10 Market

Severe weather and flooding coverage. Major-market evening news. Texas-scale breaking news leadership.

CBS News Miami

MIAMI, FL

Asst News Director · 100+ Staff

Hurricanes Ian and Nicole. Morning show revamp. 24-hour streaming launch. 50+ hires in one year.

WISH-TV

INDIANAPOLIS, IN

Producer · Newsroom Leadership

Colts Super Bowl coverage. Butler NCAA Championship run. Tornado coverage. Major-market breaking news command.

FOX 17

GRAND RAPIDS, MI

Assistant News Director

Station rebrand. Built FOX 17 into a real competitive force on market return. Editorial identity built from scratch.

NBC Bay Area

SAN FRANCISCO, CA

Executive Producer · Today in the Bay

Wildfires. Earthquakes. Drought. Bay Area heatwaves. OTT programming. Top-10 market morning leadership.

WKAR News / MSU

EAST LANSING, MI

News Director · Public Media

The Signal. Digital transformation. Politics 2026. Enterprise hubs. Student mentorship. AI experimentation.



NBC Bay Area



CBS News Miami



Golden Gate — High Fire Danger



WOOD TV8 — Career Foundation

"The platforms changed. The filter did not: does this matter?"

HOW I LEAD A NEWSROOM.

01 **Impact Filter**

Every story must pass the so-what test. If it doesn't change how someone understands their world, reconsider.

02 **Civic Intelligence Over Commodity News**

Don't waste scarce newsroom capacity duplicating what others have. Build coverage around what shapes people's lives.

03 **Digital First, Not Digital Afterthought**

Stories should be planned for how audiences actually find, read, share and use them. Not reverse-engineered from broadcast.

04 **Social Media Is a Beat**

Listen where communities talk — Nextdoor, Reddit, Facebook Groups. Stories surface there before they surface anywhere else.

05 **Weather & Climate as Public Service**

Weather is safety, utility, explanation and trust. It is where journalism meets people's daily lives most directly.

06 **AI as Infrastructure**

AI should help small newsrooms track more and see more. Human journalists maintain all editorial judgment.

07 **Team Development**

Strong newsrooms are built through coaching, trust, clarity and standards. Great leadership shows in the quality of work.

CONTACT

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Newsroom leader. Product builder.

Civic strategist. Digital transformer.



"This is a leader who can run the room during a wildfire, build a newsletter from scratch, grow digital audience, mentor young journalists, and prototype AI systems after hours — because he is obsessed with making local journalism more useful."